

Custom Agent Guidance

Bounded roles, explicit tools, human review

Preflight

Before a live exercise, verify current documentation and customer policy for:

- repository and data boundary;
- supported surface and profile syntax;
- permitted tools and MCP access;
- reviewer, meter, escalation, and stop guard.

Use a non-sensitive starter task. A manual profile review is the fallback.

An agent is guidance, not a separate employee

Custom agents make a repeatable role easier to invoke. They do not create an independent owner or remove the need for review.

A good role charter answers:

Question	Example answer
What work?	Add tests for an existing validation function
What evidence?	Target code, nearby tests, and test output
What may change?	Named test files only
Who decides?	The pull-request reviewer

The narrower the role, the easier it is to review and improve.

Separate instructions from permissions

An agent profile can tell the model to use a tool. The tool and environment decide whether that action is actually permitted.

Profile instruction: Run the focused unit test.

Environment policy: Commands are limited to an approved test runner.

Human decision: Review the diff and result before merge.

Do not write profiles that imply approval, deployment authority, or access they cannot enforce.

Review an agent with a hostile example

Give the role a request that should make it stop:

The failing test appears to need a production-code change.

The test-writer should report the boundary and hand the work back. If it edits production code anyway, the charter is too loose or the tools are too broad.

A role charter

```
.github/agents/  
└─ test-writer.md
```

A profile names one job, allowed inputs and tools, validation, stop conditions, and a manual fallback. It does not grant new authority.

Least privilege

Need	Capability	Decision
Read target and tests	Repository read/search	Allow if approved
Add test	Edit named test file	Allow if approved
Run known test	Command execution	Conditional
External data	MCP or network	Remove unless needed
Merge	Privileged action	Human only

Demo task

```
Add tests for `validateEmail`.  
- `"ada@example.com"` returns `true`.  
- `"invalid"` returns `false`.  
- `` returns `false`.  
- Change tests only.  
- Run the verified focused test command.
```

Review the diff and test result separately. Stop if production code needs to change.

Pick the smallest extension

Need	Use
Repository convention	Instructions
Repeatable procedure	Skill
Specialized role	Custom agent
Approved external capability	MCP

Lab

Create and review a test-writer and documentation profile. Use the data-analyst exercise only after its MCP server is approved.